

With over a dozen devices in the line-up, the iPod ecosystem was a niche in itself. The simple and minimal design of these devices particular of Apple, made it easy for the iPod to hold a significant place in the market.

When Apple discontinued the much-loved iPod Classic in 2014, the further cut that came in July this year was inevitable – for in a wireless age, Nano and Shuffle remained the last two products that could not stream music from Apple Music.

Why all the hype about the iPod anyway?

Developed to provide a better alternative to existing digital music players, the iPod was meant to simplify a user's experience of listening to music. The storage capacity it offered was also unheard of during those days. Even with compressed music files freely available, being able to carry your entire music collection was quite a thing (back then 1000 songs was a full collection). The device was responsible for giving Apple the push it needed to make a comeback into the tech world. Though if you contrast those early features with what's available today, the absence of Wi-Fi or cloud connectivity make it sound almost archaic now.

The 'Others'

When it comes to music players, the iPod remains a popular option because Apple has a loyal customer base for its products. As Nano and Shuffle are taken off the market, users still have cheaper MP3 player options.

For the brand-conscious, and those who think their phones aren't enough, the Sony NW-E394 in its 8GB is a good example of a stand alone music player. The variant comes at about \$75, and you have the added advantage of a radio player which the iPod isn't equipped with. There are other options which are capable of playing Hi-Res music as well. They feature high end DAC chips and Op-Amps. Brands like FiiO, and Astell & Kern are known in this category.

An interesting fact which should be considered is that despite the crippling of the iPod, it has stayed around for good 16 years. The simplicity of the design, the ability to 'own' music and not just stream it, made it capable to stay around for a long time and even when smartphones were gaining all the popularity. Even though there were other mp3 music players in the market, the uniqueness of the product was enough for its success.